

FROM CHALLENGE TO PITCH

A crash course in design thinking for a hackathon

THE WHOLE PROCESS

4 moves. 9 steps. Start with the problem and the people, build the smallest useful proof, test what matters, and tell one clear story.

IF YOU READ NOTHING ELSE, WATCH THIS!

IDEO U Design Thinking

14 min overview >

HACKATHON RULE

Timebox every move. Protect time for testing and the pitch. If behind, reduce scope - do not skip validation.

MOVE 1

DISCOVER

Understand the case before choosing a solution.

01

Understand

START WITH THE SITUATION, NOT THE TECHNOLOGY.

DO

- Who is affected and what are they trying to achieve?
- What blocks them today?
- Why does it matter?

CAPTURE

[Customer] struggles to [goal] because [obstacle], resulting in [consequence].

CHECKPOINT

Can you explain the problem without naming a technology?

02

Empathize

INVESTIGATE REAL EXPERIENCES.

DO

- Ask about the last real occurrence.
- What did they do instead?
- Where did it become difficult?

CAPTURE

We learned [evidence]. We think [interpretation]. We still need to verify [assumption].

CHECKPOINT

Can you describe the problem from the customer's perspective?

03

Define

TURN LEARNING INTO A SHARED DIRECTION.

DO

- What outcome should change for the customer?
- What context or constraint matters?
- What would success look like?

CAPTURE

How might we help [customer] achieve [outcome] when [constraint]?

CHECKPOINT

Is everyone solving the same challenge?

MOVE 2

CHOOSE

Create options, then decide what you need to prove.

04

Create

ONE IDEA IS A REACTION. SEVERAL CREATE A CHOICE.

DO

- Generate individually, then share and combine.
- Compare problem fit, customer value, feasibility and testability.

CAPTURE

We selected [concept] because [evidence and criteria].

CHECKPOINT

Can you explain why this concept beat the alternatives?

05

De-risk

FIND THE ASSUMPTION THAT COULD SINK THE IDEA.

DO

- List desirability, feasibility and viability assumptions.
- Pick the most critical and least supported.

CAPTURE

We believe [assumption]. If false, [consequence]. Test: [experiment].

CHECKPOINT

Do you know what the prototype must help you learn?

GO DEEPER



Stanford Design Thinking Bootleg

Full-process toolkit



IDEO.org Field Guide

Human-centered design toolkit

BUILD WHAT MATTERS.

LEARN FAST. MAKE IT CREDIBLE.

The prototype is evidence, not the finish line.

1 DISCOVER

2 CHOOSE

3 PROVE

4 MAKE IT REAL

MOVE 3

PROVE

Build the smallest useful proof, then test it.

06

Build

SHOW THE VALUE. SKIP THE FEATURE BUFFET.

DO

- Define: must demonstrate / useful if time / not now.
- Use the lightest prototype that makes the core idea testable.
- A mock-up, storyboard, PoC or simulated service can be enough.

CAPTURE

Our prototype shows how [customer] uses [solution] to achieve [outcome].

CHECKPOINT

Does every feature help prove the core value?

07

Test

"THEY LIKED IT" IS NOT ENOUGH.

DO

- Give someone a realistic scenario.
- Observe before helping.
- Capture confusion, evidence and what you will change.

CAPTURE

Worked: [] Confused: [] Evidence: [] Change: []

CHECKPOINT

Can you explain what changed because of testing?

MOVE 4

MAKE IT REAL

Return to the problem: show impact and tell one clear story.

08

Make it real

WHAT HAPPENS AFTER THE HACKATHON?

DO

- Who will use, approve, fund, own and maintain it?
- What tech, data or partners are needed?
- What is the next experiment?

CAPTURE

Next: [action] | Owner/partner: [who] | Question answered: [what]

CHECKPOINT

Can you name one credible next step?

09

Pitch

PROBLEM. EVIDENCE. SOLUTION. PROOF. NEXT STEP.

DO

- Problem + customer + evidence
- Solution + prototype + learning
- Next step + implementation

CAPTURE

We help [customer] overcome [problem] through [solution], enabling [outcome].

CHECKPOINT

Can the jury follow the line from problem to evidence to solution?

JUDGE-READY IN 60 SECONDS

Can you answer these five questions without opening another slide?

- 1 What problem matters?
- 2 What evidence supports it?
- 3 What did you build?
- 4 What did you learn?
- 5 What happens next?



LEARN SOMETHING NEW? GO BACK.

The process is a loop, not a checklist. Follow the evidence and revisit earlier moves when needed.